

Thesis Presented to POINT  
PARK UNIVERSITY

# Understanding the Noise Of Today's Political Climate

Submitted in partial satisfaction of the requirements  
for the degree of

BACHELOR OF FINE ARTS

in Photography

by

Caleb McCartney

2025

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## DEDICATION

# CURRICULUM VITAE

## **Education**

2025     BFA, Photography, Point Park University, Pittsburgh, PA

## **Awards & Fellowships**

2025     Golden Quill Nomination, Student Excellence in Journalistic Craft Achievement  
News photo, The Globe, Pittsburgh, PA

2024     School Of Communication Photo Editor Apprenticeship, Pittsburgh, PA

2024     Keystone Media Award, Pennsylvania News Media Association, Harrisburg, PA

2021     President's Scholarship, Point Park University, Pittsburgh, PA

## **Professional Appointments**

2024     Photojournalist, New York Post, Pittsburgh, PA

2024     Photographer, Terrible Tailgate, Pittsburgh, PA

2024     Photo Editor, The Globe, Pittsburgh, PA

2022     Photographer, GradImages. Pittsburgh PA

2022     Staff Photographer, The Globe, Pittsburgh, PA

## **Professional Experiences**

- 2025      Thesis Artist Talk, Point Park University, Pittsburgh, PA, Presenter
- 2025      Regional Open Portfolio, Artists Image Resource, Pittsburgh, PA, Participant  
Presenter
- 2023      Regional Open Portfolio, Artists Image Resource, Pittsburgh, PA, Participant  
Presenter

## **Technical Abilities**

- 2021–Present      Expertise in DSLR & Mirrorless cameras, film processing (35mm, 120mm), Adobe Suite (Photoshop et al.), Capture One, Photo Mechanics, Darkroom Operations, and Digital Marketing Platforms (SEO, social media).

## **Creative Abilities**

- 2021–Present      Creative Direction, Team Leadership, Content Strategy, Graphic Design, Trend Analysis, Client Relations, Project Management, and Visual Storytelling

## **Exhibitions**

- 2025      Thesis Exhibition, Letting Me Go, Artist Image Resources, Pittsburgh, PA
- 2022      Group Exhibition, Stranger Than Known, Artist Image Resources, Pittsburgh, PA
- 2022      Group Site Piece, What I Want the World to See, Point Park University, Pittsburgh, PA

## **Clients**

- 2025      Upward Consulting, Event Photographer, Pittsburgh, PA

2025 Covalent, Creative Director & Producer, Pittsburgh, PA

2024 Next Generation News Service, Photojournalist, Pittsburgh, PA

2024 New York Post, Photojournalist, Greensburgh, PA

2024 Shepherd USA, Event Photographer, Cannonsburgh, PA

2024 The Globe, Photo Editor, Pittsburgh, PA

2024 Penn State Fayette, Dance Photographer, Fayette County, PA

2024 Point Park University, Event Photographer, Pittsburgh, PA

2024 Pennsylvania News Media Association, Event Photographer, Harrisburg, PA

2023 James Bond Soiree & Cocktail Party, Event Photographer, Washington & Pittsburgh, PA

2022 April Friges, Producer on Art Documentary, Pittsburgh, PA

2022 Associated Artists of Pittsburgh Headshots, Art Director & Photographer, Pittsburgh, PA

## **Publications**

2025 Hakas, A. (2025, June 6). Pittsburgh's Downtown YWCA was Supposed to Be Turned into 300 Apartments. What Happened? Pittsburgh Magazine.  
<https://www.pittsburghmagazine.com/pittsburghs-downtown-ywca-300-new-apartments-project-stalled/>

2025 Hakas, A. (2025, May 27). From the Next Generation Newsroom: Pittsburgh aims to fix more battered sidewalks. Pittsburgh Union Progress.  
<https://www.unionprogress.com/2025/05/27/from-the-next-generation-newsroom-pittsburgh-aims-to-fix-more-battered-sidewalks/>

- 2024     “Bill Clinton claims Israeli leaders ‘do not care anymore’ about Middle East peace, says Kamala Harris ‘cannot have’ plan to end war  
” Digital Newspaper, The New York Post, Sean Giancola,  
nypost.com/2024/10/29/us-news/bill-Clinton-says-Israeli-leaders-don't-care-f  
or Mideast-peace-says-kamala-harris-cant-have-plan-to-end-war/
- 2024     “Obama Rallies for Harris in Pittsburgh,” Print Newspaper, The Globe, Point Park  
University Publishing,  
[ppuglobe.com/2024/10/obama-rallies-for-harris-in-Pittsburgh](http://ppuglobe.com/2024/10/obama-rallies-for-harris-in-Pittsburgh)
- 2024     “Kamala Harris Campaigns in Erie”, Print Newspaper, The Globe, Point Park  
University Publishing, [ppuglobe.com/2024/10/kamala-harris-campaigns-in-Erie](http://ppuglobe.com/2024/10/kamala-harris-campaigns-in-Erie)
- 2024     “The Point” Print Magazine, Point Park University Publishing

### **Professional Memberships**

- 2024     National Press Photographers Association (NPPA)
- 2023     Professional Photographers of America (PPA)

# **ABSTRACT**

Understanding the Noise Of Today's Political Climate

By

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Bachelor of Fine Arts in Photography

Point Park University, Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania, 2024

Political anxiety has intensified in the modern era as ideological divisions deepen, transforming political engagement into an emotional battleground. Beyond policy and governance, politics has become a space where personal identity, fear, and notions of belonging intersect. Individuals do not merely advocate for their beliefs; they defend them as extensions of themselves, making opposition feel like a direct threat. The heightened emotional investment fuels hostility, reactionary discourse, and an increasing inability to engage with differing perspectives.

I examine political anxiety through the lens of Carl Jung's shadow theory, exploring how individuals and groups project their suppressed fears and insecurities onto their perceived adversaries. The concept of the collective shadow offers insight into how political polarization extends beyond ideology to a deeply psychological level. Political opponents often reflect unacknowledged aspects of the self—qualities people reject within themselves but quickly identify in others. This mechanism reinforces division, making meaningful dialogue nearly impossible.

Through firsthand experiences as a photojournalist covering political events, I analyze the tension between performance and reality in political spaces. Photography serves as a means of documentation and analysis, capturing moments where collective belief is celebrated and division fractures that unity. This work aims to expose the emotional and psychological currents driving modern political engagement, raising critical questions about the nature of opposition, the fear of self-confrontation, and the unseen forces that shape the political landscape.

## Psychological Roots of Political Anxiety

Politics often revolves around public personas, catchphrases, and staged events. However, the tensions I witnessed—whether at a Tim Walz rally in Erie or a Trump rally in Butler—suggest a strong undercurrent of anxiety rooted in unacknowledged fears and desires. These hidden elements, which psychologists like Carl Jung refer to as the “shadow,” are not just personal—they also shape collective mindsets. Understanding how this shadow

operates at the individual level is the first step toward grasping the broader psychological dynamics behind modern political conflicts.

Bringing Jung's framework into this conversation helps illuminate why seemingly routine campaign stops or debates can trigger such robust emotional responses. The shadow holds qualities we deny in ourselves—anger, resentment, vulnerability—but also latent creativity and insight we have not fully integrated. When these disowned traits become projected onto opposing parties or public figures, everyday political discourse morphs into a stage for deeper psychological battles. Recognizing these mechanisms sheds light on the intensity of partisan clashes and points to a more reflective form of engagement, where individuals grapple with their fears and biases before directing them outward.

In this context, political events are not merely about candidate promises or policy positions; they are also arenas where we confront—or evade—the aspects of ourselves we would rather not face. By understanding the shadow's role in shaping individual and collective behavior, we gain greater clarity on the roots of modern political anxiety.

## 1.1 Carl Jung's Shadow and Individualisation

Carl Jung's concept of the shadow addresses the hidden parts of ourselves—the traits, emotions, and desires we reject or suppress because they conflict with how we want to be perceived or how society expects us to behave. The shadow is, as Jung described, “the thing a person has no wish to be” (Jung, CW16, para. 470). It represents a repository for everything we do not acknowledge, often surfacing unexpectedly in moments of projection,

outbursts, or defensiveness. It is the side of us we rarely show others, yet it profoundly influences how we interact with the world.

The shadow, Jung explains, is neither inherently good nor bad. It contains morally reprehensible tendencies and qualities valuable for growth, such as instincts, creativity, and insights (Jung, CW9, paras. 422–423). This complexity makes the shadow an essential part of our psyche that requires understanding and engagement, much like our ego. However, failure to recognize or integrate the shadow often leads to interpersonal conflict and prejudice, which can manifest on both small and large scales—from personal disputes to societal divisions and wars (The Society of Analytical Psychology).

Dissociation often serves as a barrier to this integration, disconnecting us from our shadows and the positive and authentic aspects of ourselves. Traumas and pivotal life events, especially those that restrict our development, play a significant role in creating this disconnection. Dissociation can isolate even the parts of ourselves that make us whole, like removing the yin from the yang. The longer we avoid confronting the shadow, the more deeply it influences our behaviors and relationships, often without conscious awareness.

Jung believed that individuation, becoming whole, requires integrating the shadow into conscious awareness. This journey involves accepting all aspects of ourselves, including our flaws and strengths, and using this understanding to develop a more authentic sense of self. In *The Odyssey*, Odysseus's struggle mirrors aspects of individuation. His hubris and dissociation from his true self drive him to fight literal and metaphorical demons. While he yearns to be a man, his journey becomes a process of reconciling his pride and vulnerabilities to achieve a deeper understanding of himself.

The consequences of an unintegrated shadow are evident in the form of political and social tensions, where suppressed fears, biases, and anxieties are projected onto opposing groups. Political discourse, particularly in moments of heightened polarization, frequently reveals the emergence of the collective shadow, where unconscious fears and resentments are externalized onto ideological adversaries. As divisions deepen, individuals and groups may find themselves trapped in cycles of reactionary behavior, unable to recognize the shared psychological mechanisms that drive their conflicts.

Jung's framework suggests that embracing the shadow fosters greater self-awareness and empathy. In the political realm, this integration could lead to more nuanced discussions and reduced reactionary hostility. However, the process requires an active willingness to confront uncomfortable truths about the self and society. Without this reflection, the shadow remains in control, fueling the anxieties and divisions that define modern political engagement.

Understanding the shadow allows us to develop empathy, not only for others but also for ourselves. Empathy is crucial to our personal growth and development. When adequately embraced, the shadow becomes a guide, helping us become the person we are meant to be. Confronting the shadow and acknowledging the parts of ourselves we are tempted to hide requires courage. However, it is in this confrontation that growth and healing begin.

## 1.2 The Collective Shadow and Political Projection

Carl Jung's concept of the shadow describes the parts of ourselves that we suppress—fears, insecurities, and contradictions we do not want to acknowledge. When left

unacknowledged, these traits persist. They emerge elsewhere, often in the form of projection. Jung writes that we “see in others the very things we refuse to see in ourselves” (Jung, CW16, para. 470). On a political level, this projection becomes collective. Groups disown their flaws and project them onto the “enemy,” fueling division through disagreement and a complete refusal to engage in self-reflection.

I have watched this unfold up close through my lens as a photojournalist. Political events often begin with celebration—flags waving, people cheering, and unified chants echoing through the air. However, there is always a moment when that surface cracks. The performance slips. That is when the real energy emerges—not joy but fear and resentment. People begin shouting conspiracy theories, not because they are rooted in truth, but because those narratives offer a sense of control. They rewrite reality to avoid facing what scares them.

One of the most chilling things I have witnessed is how easily people embrace authoritarianism while believing they are fighting for freedom. I have stood in crowds where people wave flags for a man who openly undermines democracy, where they chant about liberty while defending policies that strip away rights. They are not just opposing another party but projecting everything they fear about themselves onto those who think differently. It is no longer about policy. It becomes personal, even existential. The other side is not just wrong—they are dangerous, evil, and corrupt. In that space, empathy disappears.

This is the collective shadow in action. Supporters of political figures with authoritarian tendencies often accuse others of brainwashing, tyranny, or censorship—all while cheering for those same behaviors in their leader. The contradiction is not lost on them because it

never fully enters their awareness. Projection protects them from confronting brutal truths. It is easier to point fingers than to look inward.

These moments, where fear takes the wheel and anger becomes identity, are not just political breakdowns but psychological ones. People are not acting purely on logic or civic responsibility. They are reacting to threats to their identity and perceived place in the world. That fear gets pushed outward and wrapped in the language of patriotism. However, underneath is the shadow—unseen, unacknowledged, and driving the very anxiety that fractures everything.

There is almost no space left for dialogue. Projection does not invite conversation—it invites enemies. I have rarely witnessed moments of empathy between divided groups. Instead, I have documented people who would rather burn everything down than admit they might be wrong. That, to me, is the most terrifying part. Because the more people externalize their shadows, the more disconnected they become from reality, and the harder it is to return from that.

### 1.3 Political Identity and the Fear of Losing Control

Political identity is often misconstrued as the outcome of rational deliberation—an expression of beliefs or loyalty to policy platforms. However, beneath the surface, psychological and emotional needs shape it just as much, particularly when individuals feel disoriented by change. In times of transition, when cultural certainties erode or systems fail to provide stability, people turn toward political identity not only as a means of expression but as a form of psychological containment. The desire for order becomes paramount.

Political affiliation, then, becomes a means of regaining control over oneself, one's environment, and the perceived trajectory of the world.

This reflexive grasp for control can be found across ideological spectrums. On one end, conservatism may respond to the fear of cultural loss, particularly the erosion of tradition, national heritage, or religious norms, by forging identities that demand the restoration of a past believed to be slipping away. Conversely, progressivism often centers its identity on the urgency of preventing future collapse, responding to the fear of injustice, environmental destruction, or democratic decay with calls for immediate and often transformative change. In both instances, the motivating force is fear, and the identity transforms that fear into meaning, community, and action.

Historical patterns affirm that fear and disorientation are fertile ground for identity consolidation. Post-World War I Germany, for example, bore witness to a population economically devastated and psychologically fractured. The rapid decline of national dignity and the failures of the Weimar Republic created a profound vacuum of control. Into this void stepped the Nazi Party, not as a rational actor in policy debates, but as an emotional answer to existential dread. Hitler's rise was fueled by promises of recovery and the construction of a political identity defined by exclusion, supremacy, and vengeance. People longed for a sense of order and significance; the cost was the dehumanization of the other.

A similar dynamic unfolded in the American South during the Civil Rights Movement. For many white Southerners, the dismantling of segregation was perceived not as progress but as a threat to a way of life. The social hierarchy that had long governed their identities was

collapsing. Political actors like George Wallace capitalized on this fear, offering a renewed identity anchored in defiance. The fear of losing social dominance was translated into a political ideology of resistance that masked fragility as strength and framed equality as a form of dispossession.

The aftermath of the September 11th terrorist attacks offers a more recent example. In the United States, the collective trauma of the attacks redefined political allegiance. Patriotism morphed into a heavily politicized identity that blurred the line between moral virtue and militarized nationalism. The need to feel safe translated into broad support for sweeping surveillance laws, military expansion, and an “us versus them” binary that cast dissent as a form of betrayal. Here again, identity hardened not around ideology alone, but around a more resounding emotional demand: to regain control in a world that no longer felt safe.

This structure persists in the contemporary American context, intensified by economic precarity, racial tension, climate anxiety, and the proliferation of digital media. On the right, political identity often arises in response to perceived loss of jobs, religious values, gender norms, or national cohesion. In contrast, on the left, identity coalesces around the fear of ongoing injustice and institutional decay. Each side frames the other not merely as an opposition, but as a threat. In this way, political identity becomes a battleground of control: who gets to define reality, whose history is remembered, and who speaks for the future.

Social media deepens this crisis of control. Algorithms prioritize emotional intensity, ensuring that fear-driven narratives rise to the top. Users are siloed into echo chambers, affirming their political identities while magnifying the danger of ideological “others.”

Political expression becomes performative, identity-bound, and reactive. Those who do not

perform loyalty to the narrative are cast out, labeled as traitors or enablers. In such a system, political discourse no longer facilitates understanding—it safeguards identity against perceived threats to its integrity.

Understanding political identity today means recognizing how fear transforms belief into a form of armor. This fear is not always irrational, nor is the desire for control inherently harmful. When fear becomes the foundation upon which identity is built, it begins to close the door to empathy, adaptability, and collective imagining. Fear has proven capable of forging communities across historical eras and ideological camps. Still, it has also justified their most destructive instincts.

If political identity is to serve more than self-preservation, it must be disentangled from the reflexive need for control. This requires confronting what lies beneath performance: vulnerability, loss, and anxiety. By facing the fear that animates identity, we can construct one that is not merely defensive but transformative—capable of meeting change without recoiling.

## 1.4 Dissociation, Polarization, and the Media's Role

Belief is not quietly held in today's political climate—it is publicly performed. Digital spaces have transformed political identity from a private orientation into a visible declaration, one that is curated and broadcast through social media, news cycles, and visual culture.

Participation is no longer just about what one thinks but how convincingly one can display

that alignment to others. In this shift, the boundary between belief and performance begins to blur.

Social and political belonging are increasingly contingent on repetition—signaling the right stance at the right time and using language and imagery that affirm group loyalty. Judith Butler’s theory of performativity provides a valuable lens: identity is not an expression of an internal self, but rather something constituted through repeated actions and socially legible behaviors (Butler, 1990). In politically polarized spaces, these repetitions—hashtags, profile banners, protest selfies, and reactions to public events—become the scripts through which people are recognized and legitimized. They are also the scripts through which individuals are surveilled, categorized, and sometimes silenced.

This performative demand introduces a quiet violence. People begin to police their speech, fearing that saying the wrong thing or nothing might strip them of social legitimacy. Silence becomes suspicious, hesitation reads as betrayal, and even nuance feels unsafe. The result is a kind of dissociation—not just from others, but from the self. Individuals may continue to participate in these performance-driven spaces, yet remain emotionally disconnected from them, unsure whether their voice truly belongs to them or is shaped by the algorithmic and ideological expectations surrounding them.

Social media does not simply reflect these dynamics—it accelerates them. Eli Pariser (2011) describes the emergence of “filter bubbles,” algorithmic environments that repeatedly display content aligned with an individual’s beliefs and values. These digital bubbles are not neutral but are curated to reinforce emotional reactions, particularly

outrage and confirmation bias. Over time, users become surrounded by a narrowed worldview that feels increasingly urgent and absolute.

I have experienced this firsthand. Most social media platforms are designed to anticipate how we will click, scroll, or engage—often by appealing to emotion over logic. As Zuboff (2019) argues, surveillance capitalism exploits human experience, using our attention, preferences, and vulnerabilities as raw materials for behavioral prediction. Just like commercials trigger desire or fear of missing out to drive behavior, social media is structured to tap into our emotional reflexes, even if what it serves us is anger. The result is like being trapped in a crowded room where everyone shouts variations of the same message. It is not a conversation—it is an emotional echo chamber. There are days when I just want a break from all the yelling and crave dialogue, but instead, I am hit with a loop of noise, stripped of context or connection.

That bubble becomes especially visible when I look at it objectively, without taking a side. Once you realize how orchestrated it all feels, it is hard to unsee it. We begin to notice how even our media preferences, movie choices, and the shows we binge all feed back into this loop of curated perspective. And it is exhausting. Sometimes, I react viscerally and can only step away—go quiet. It feels like being stuck at a massive party you did not want to attend, but cannot entirely leave. That fear of missing out, of losing the thread of what is happening, is overwhelming. According to the Pew Research Center (2014), individuals with strongly ideological views are more likely to disengage from opposing perspectives, thereby further intensifying polarization and heightening the pressure to hold firm to their beliefs. We have been living in a fear-of-missing-out epidemic, and the media

cycle—especially the political one—has turned into a never-ending performance. Miss a day, and it feels like you have skipped an episode. You are behind, lost, and struggling to catch up.

This fear does not just apply to what we consume—it affects how we create. There have been moments when I have taken a photograph and then hesitated, wondering whether it would be misinterpreted. One moment that stands out to me is a photo I took of Tim Walz in Erie. He looked tired, sad, and even. From where I stood, I knew that sadness came from integrity. He had just finished talking to veterans, and his face reflected the weight of it.

However, I could not help wondering how the image might be misused out of context.

Would someone twist it to paint him as weak? Would they assume it was a political defeat?

That fear lingers because many people are trained to retaliate first rather than pause to see someone as a human being.

We are not taught to analyze images, yet we use them constantly, often substituting them for reading or listening. We expect photographs to tell stories, but we rarely ask what has been cropped out, what moment came before or after, what truth might be more complicated than what is visible. Moreover, as someone behind the lens, I feel the weight of that responsibility. As Butler (1997) reminds us, identity and expression do not exist in a vacuum—they are shaped by social context and the risk of misrecognition. I do not want to be misunderstood, and I do not like the people I photograph to be reduced to symbols of a narrative they never chose to be part of.

# The Firehose I Call Political Photojournalism

## 2.1 Experiencing the Firehose

Photojournalism has become more than an act of documentation—it is a way to process my internal struggles and find clarity. Capturing political moments helps me deal with the frustration and chaos that feel unmanageable without a camera. As Roland Barthes suggests, "We photograph things to drive them out of our minds" (Barthes, 1981, p. 55). In the same way, my camera allows me to remove that noise and chaos from my mind, making sense of it through the image.

Barthes discusses the *stadium* in photography as an image's predictable, socially understood meaning. In politics, this concept feels ever-present. Politicians are often reduced to predictable gestures and expressions, making them think rehearsed or expected. For example, the same calculated smiles, handshakes, or points into the crowd define their public personas. Similarly, the audience is caught up in expected reactions—applauding at the right moment or shaking their heads in dissent. This banality becomes the stadium, the surface-level message of the event (Barthes, 1981, p. 27).

However, as Barthes describes, the *punctum* is different. The small detail or moment breaks through predictability, creating a more profound emotional impact. For me, it is often found in the unguarded expressions of doubt or discomfort on a politician's face or a fleeting look of vulnerability in an audience member. These moments stand out, forcing me to pause and reflect. They are reminders of that shadow—the parts I see reflected in others.

Jung's concept of the shadow speaks to this process. He writes that the shadow is the unseen part of ourselves that emerges during conflict or tension. I see this tension in the faces of the politicians and the crowd, wondering what they might be suppressing or avoiding. Are they ignoring their vulnerabilities?

When Barthes says, "To see a photograph well, it is best to look away or close your eyes" (Barthes, 1981, p. 55), I think about how capturing these moments allows me to step back and reflect on them in a way I could not do in real time. The camera becomes a way to process these thoughts—what I see in others and recognize in myself. I use it to capture the quiet moments where the noise fades, and the external world mirrors the internal one, creating a dialogue between what is visible and what is hidden.

Photojournalism has become a way to reckon with my shadow through this process. The chaos of political spaces often provides clarity that I struggle to find elsewhere. It has also shown me how closely connected we are, no matter our roles. The lens becomes not just a tool for capturing moments but for understanding them—for understanding myself.

## 2.2 Performance vs. Reality

Lights dim, playlists swell, and a podium glows like the headliner's mic stand. Neil Postman warned that once politics slips onto the entertainment grid, "the idea is not to pursue excellence, clarity, or honesty, but to appear as if you are" (Postman, 2006, p. 107). From the press pen, I watch the choreography: a smile held just long enough for the jumbotron, a chant timed for a thirty-second clip, a spotlight cue that makes every slogan feel sunrise-bright.

John Berger reminds me that “we never look at just one thing; we are always looking at the relation between things and ourselves” (Berger, 2008, p. 7). Any frame I choose—wide euphoria or tight anxiety—silently declares what matters. More than once, I have defaulted to the cleaner, more compelling crop that flatters the campaign storyboard, while a messier angle (such as someone yawning or a security guard rolling their eyes) might tell a more accurate tale.

Then the feeding frenzy begins. Larry Sabato calls it the moment “a critical mass of journalists leaps to cover the same embarrassing or scandalous subject and pursue it intensely, often uncontrollably” (Sabato & Lamb, 1994). Cameras pivot toward a protester’s outburst, the housing-policy slide flicks past unnoticed, and substance evaporates into a meme. Worse, rumor often outruns evidence: “If it is rumored, then it is completely improper to print it unless you have the evidence to prove it” (Sabato & Lamb, 1994), yet whispers still make headlines “using the justification that it is affecting the campaigns” (Sabato & Lamb, 1994). Each time a chant built on an unverified claim crescendos, my shutter becomes an ethical dial—echo the rumor or stay grounded in verifiable truth.

Postman’s deeper claim lands hard here: today’s messages “tell nothing about the products being sold; they tell everything about the fears, fancies, and dreams of those who might buy them” (Postman, 2005, p. 109). Swap corporate jingles for stump-speech mantras, and candidates become brand extensions. Placards flash like concert merchandise; LED backdrops promise safety, rebellion, or a sense of belonging. My photographs capture that moment: the retiree whose clenched jaw betrays dread over her pension, the student grinning at the possibility of purpose, the family in matching shirts absorbing a ready-made

identity. People may cheer against their material interests yet still buy a story calibrated to soothe private anxieties.

Berger cuts even closer to the bone, warning that “capitalism survives by forcing the majority, whom it exploits, to define their interests as narrowly as possible ... by imposing a false standard of what is and is not desirable” (Berger, 2008, p. 179). That line could caption two prints in my exhibition: twin blocks of red, white, and blue, nearly identical at first glance, each tilting a single word in an opposite direction. Viewers swear they “see” different slogans—even though the shapes, palette, and typeweight never change. Shrink the field of vision, swap nuance for a color cue, and desire bends to whichever word lands first. Suppose Postman shows how the spectacle sells identity. In that case, these companion shots reveal the cost—citizens buying into a story so narrowly framed that even the simplest language splits into rival banners.

## Conclusion

The most human moments I witnessed were not the chants, the outrage, or the performances. It was what happened after, when the shouting quieted. When the speeches ended, people stood in silence, unsure of what to do next. Those moments — when a mask slipped, when a sob cracked through the tension, or when someone’s expression turned blank from exhaustion — those were real. Vulnerability surfaced not in loud declarations but in stillness. And it was in those quiet ruptures, not the theater, where truth resided.

Something is terrifying about witnessing someone switch personas the moment a political idol appears — the way people contort themselves to belong. But what is more unsettling is

how familiar it became. I saw myself in them. I realized I was also performing. I was masking the toll this all was taking — dissociating not just as a psychological defense, but as a ritual of survival in the firehose of this political moment. I did not want to feel what I was documenting. So I started to seek out the subtle, the small. The details that others overlook, the subtle gestures, the people on the margins, the authenticity that does not trend. In doing so, I began to unmask myself.

We are a reactive society. We are taught to fear “the other” before we even ask who they are. However, the way forward is not in more noise, but in more gentleness, not in passivity, but in presence. If there is any hope for healing this climate of political anxiety, it lies in becoming uncomfortable in a violent yet vulnerable way. And here is where artists and journalists must walk a tightrope: to document the anxiety honestly without feeding it. To create space for reflection without dictating what should be seen. To offer images not as weapons, but as mirrors.

This work has cost me. Time, energy, relationships — moments I will not get back. However, it has also given me a gift: perspective. I have seen things most people my age have not. I have carried stories that are not mine, and watched them unfold through the lens of someone trying to understand, not judge. And in all of that, I have started to come back to myself. I am no longer hiding in the shadows of dissociation. I am learning to stay present in the discomfort. To make sense of the noise by listening to it, instead of shouting over it.

At the heart of this is not just anxiety, but humanity itself. Flawed, fractured, but still reaching.



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